laughing and joking with me in the way he had for most of the last ten years. The game at Everton was a trip down the East Lancs Road to pickup the silverware. We were already champions before we kicked off on the last day of the season. The atmosphere in our dressing room during those few weeks had been as strong as I could remember at any time during my United career. I loved it now, feeling back in the thick of things with the lads. For a few days, anyway, those moments in front of the television watching the manager seemed not to matter. I couldn't really believe I'd ever have to walkaway from this group of players, this marvelous soccer club. I enjoyed the celebrations after beating Everton 2–1 as much as anybody. I'd even scored the first goal. Because we'd had to come from so far behind to beat Arsenal, this Premiership trophy was one we'd really had to work hard together to earn. We hadn't lost a League game since the turn of the year. On the field at the final whistle, as we paraded the trophy, and in the dressing room afterwards, I felt part of it all again. If you'd asked me that afternoon if I was leaving United, I'd have told you:

'Not in a million years.'

I won't ever forget the feeling: winning in a United shirt. The million years, though? I was gone in less than five weeks.

Two things happened in the middle of May after the season ended. The first was that United's chief executive, Peter Kenyon, said that if someone offered enough money for me, the club would have to think about selling me. I know how things get taken out of context, but to me that sounded all wrong. I didn't want to leave. Peter had asked me himself, face to face, a year before and I hadn't changed. I thought I knew what the gaffer's feelings were but I believed things between us could be straightened out as long as the club still wanted me. Now, it didn't sound to me like they did. On May 14, I had a new United contract put in front of me. I know some supporters probably thought: well, if you want to stay at Old Trafford, why don't you just sign it? Maybe that was what the boss would have been thinking as well.

My previous deal, agreed less than a year before, had taken a year and a half to sort out. The club had been very fair and open in their dealings with me over it. Now, all of a sudden, they stuck a new one in front of me as if to say: sign this or forget it. Despite what some people said or wrote at the time, my future at United was never going to be about money. In fact, the new contract included a pay rise. I remember talking to Dad about how I felt:

'The only reason I'd ever leave United is if I could see they wanted me to.